Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, 15-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
- © 2026 Bill Wetzel - Licensed under CC BY 4.0
  https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/

1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
                v – enter select mode
                3 – select 3
                w – words
                d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
               wd – delete word
               xc – change line
               %y – yank entire file
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
               gd – go to definition
               gy – go to type definition
               gr – go to references
               gi – go to implementatio

               ]d – next diagnostic
               [d – prior diagnostic
               ]D – last diagnostic
               [D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
           ]f, [f – to next, prior functi
           ]t, [t – to next, prior type d
           ]T, [T – to next, prior test
           ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
           ]c, [c – to next, prior comm
           ]g, [g – to next, prior chang
           ]G, [G – to last, first change

          Alt-e – move to end of pare
          Alt-b – move to start of par
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
          Ctrl-b – page up
          Ctrl-f – page down
          Ctrl-u – half page up
          Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between ancho
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
               % – select whole file
          Alt-; – swap anchor and cu
          Alt-: – selection to normal
          Alt-o – expand selection sy
          Alt-i – shrink selection
              ; – collapse selection(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
     ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match arou
                       below:
             w / W – word / WO
                 p – paragraph
     (, [, ', etc. – specified su
                 m –  closest su
                 f – function
                 t – type or cla
                 a – argument/
                 c – comment
                 T – test
                 g – change git
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
             w / W – to start of next wor
             e / E – to end of current wo
```

1.5 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape metachars with backslash when searching for literal value.

```
  .  – any character
  *  – zero or more
  +  – one or more
  ?  – zero or one / lazy modifier
  ^  – start of line / negation in class
  $  – end of line
( )  – capture group
[ ]  – character class
{ }  – repetition count
  |  – alternation
  \  – escape character itself
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
          u / U  – undo / redo change in linear history
  Alt-u / Alt-U  – move backward / forward in tree history
    :ear / :lat  – move backward / forward in history by step count or time span
                   (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
     <nn><cmd>   – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
           Esc   – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
       :wq  – write current buffer and quit
  :wq <file>  – write current buffer to <file> and quit
      :wqa  – write all buffer(s) and quit
       :q  – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
   :o <file>  – open <file> in new buffer
   :w <file>  – write current buffer to <file>

  :hs <file>  – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
  :vs <file>  – open/create <file> in new vertical split
        ␣wf  – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
        ␣wF  – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
          gf  – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.

        ␣f  – open file picker at LSP workspace root
        ␣F  – open file picker at current working directory
        ␣g  – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
  <enter>  – open selected in current view
   Ctrl-s  – open selected in new horizontal split
   Ctrl-v  – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
      :n  – create new scratch buffer
     :bc  – close current buffer
    :bca  – close all buffers
    :bco  – close all but current buffer
     :bn  – next buffer
      ␣b  – open buffer picker

     ga  – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
     gm  – go to last modified/alternate buffer
```

```
  b / B  – to start of current w
      x  – current line, extend
      X  – extend to line
 Alt-x  – shrink to line bound
     ]p  – to next paragraph
     [p  – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
  Alt-o  – expand selection to
  Alt-i  – shrink syntax tree o
  Alt-p  – select previous sibli
  Alt-n  – select next sibling n
  Alt-a  – select all sibling nod
  Alt-I  – select all children no
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
  f<ch>, F<ch>  – to <ch> inclusiv
  t<ch>, T<ch>  – to <ch> exclusiv
       Alt-.  – repeat last find
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
      v  – toggle select mode
    Esc  – return to normal
      )  – cycle primary select
      (  – cycle primary select
  Alt-,  – remove primary sele
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
  s<regex>  – matches become sel
         S  – split on match
    Alt-s  – split on newlines
  C, Alt-C  – add selection below,
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
          &  – align on primary cu
Alt-<minus>  – merge selections
Alt-<under>  – merge consecutive s
        ,  – remove all except pr
    Alt-,  – remove primary sele
    ( / )  – rotate primary back
Alt-( / Alt-)  – rotate content back
        K  – keep selections mat
    Alt-K  – remove selections m
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
  i  – before selection
  a  – after selection
  I  – at start of line
  A  – at end of line
  o  – add line and insert b
```

```
gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
gn – go to next buffer
gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and ␣w are synonymous.

```
␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
␣wq – close current split
␣wo – close all but current split
␣ww – next split

␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

zz, zc – align to center
zt – align to top
zb – align to bottom
zm – align to middle horizontally
zj – scroll down
zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
:tutor – open tutorial
␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
gh, g| – beginning of line
<nn>g| – column <nn>
gl – end of line
gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
ge – bottom of file
gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word

g.– to last modification in current file
gj – down textual line
gk – up textual line

gs – first non-white-space char
gt – top of screen
gc – middle of screen
gb – bottom of screen
```

```
O – add line and insert a
Esc – end insert (return to
. – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
]␣ – newline below
[␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> arou
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
d – selection -> yank bu
Alt-d – delete, no save
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> ar
```

2.6.4 Change

```
c – selection -> yank bu
Alt-c – change, no save
= – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> – Indent line(s) contai
< – Undent line(s) conta
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
~ – change case
` – set lowercase
Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
␣C – Toggle block comme
␣Alt-C – Toggle line commen
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selec
Ctrl-x – decrement the selec
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
J – join lines in a selecti
Alt-J – join lines inside sele
<under> – trim whitespace fro
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <w
:sort – sort ranges in select
:format – format file using ext
```

n

on

on
efinition

ent
e

nt node in syntax tree
ent node in syntax tree

or and cursor

rsor
direction (cursor at end)
ntax-aware

to cursor(s)

und / inside the object indicated by <ch>

RD

urround pairs
round pair

ss
parameter

hunk

d / WORD
ord / WORD

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
      y – selection -> yank buf
      p – paste yank buf after the cursor
      P – paste yank buf before the cursor
     ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
     ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
 ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
     ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
  r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
      R – replace selection with yank buf
      " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
  /<regex> – search forward for regex
  ?<regex> – search backward for regex
     n, N – next, previous match
        * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
   "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
  "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
  "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
  "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
  "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
  "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
  Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
  Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
  Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
      ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
        mm – go to matching delim
   mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
   ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
   ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
   md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
   Alt-| – ignore output
      ! – insert output before each selection(s)
   Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
      $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

word / WORD
by line

s

parent syntax node
bject selection
ng node in syntax tree
ode in syntax tree
les in syntax tree
odes in syntax tree

e (find)
e (till)
/ till

ion forward
ion backward
ection

is *primary*.

ections

above

rsor

selections
rimary selection
ection
wards / forwards
ward / forward
ching the regex
natching the regex

below cursor

␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.15 Editor Configuration

:config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
:config-reload – reload the config file

2.16 Miscellaneous

␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
Ctrl-x – autocomplete
Ctrl-r – insert a register content
Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End> – usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
<enter> – open selected
<tab> – select next completion item
<backtab> – select previous completion item
Alt-b – backward a word
Ctrl-b – backward a char
Alt-f – forward a word
Ctrl-f – forward a char
Ctrl-e – to prompt end
Ctrl-a – to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
<bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
<del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
Ctrl-p – select previous history
Ctrl-n – select next history
Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
<Home> – to first entry
<End> – to last entry

above cursor
o normal)

nd selection

f, delete selection

ound selection

f, change selection

with <ch2>

ning selection
ining selection

ent
t

ted number
ted number

ion
ction and select the inserted space
m selection
width>, default 80
tion
ternal formatter / language server

```
Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
<enter> – open selected
Alt-<enter> – open selected in the background without
              closing the picker
Ctrl-s – open horizontally
Ctrl-v – open vertically
Ctrl-t – toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
Ctrl-u – scroll up
Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
<enter> – close menu and accept completion
Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p – previous signature
Alt-n – next signature
```